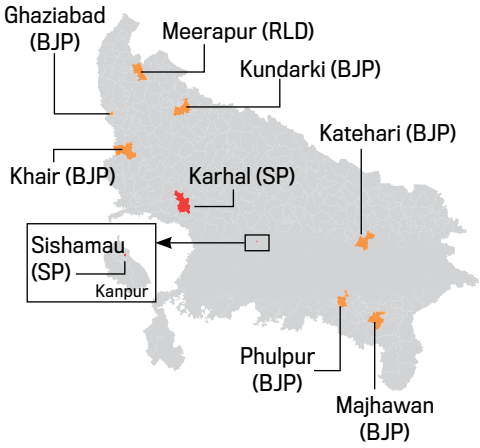


Sabha election. Organisational strength played a key role, as both Yogi and his polarising slogan got the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's stamp of approval. The BJP also made strategic moves to balance caste representation, fielding four OBC candidates, all of whom won. Even in a constituency like Kundarki, with a 62 per cent Muslim population, the saffron party came up trumps after 31 years.

While the ruling party's narrative focused on consolidating Hindu voters, driving home the message of a perceived threat, Samajwadi Party (SP) chief Akhilesh Yadav's unity-driven "*judenge to jeetenge*" (United, we win) pitch failed to galvanise the diverse coalition of voters he sought to mobilise under his PDA—*pichhda* (backward), Dalit and *alpasankhyak* (minority)—strategy. The net result: the BJP has further consolidated its position with 257 seats, up from 255 it won in 2022. The SP, on the other hand, is left with 107 legislators in the 403-member assembly.

The outcome is in stark contrast to the parliamentary election results in June, when the BJP saw its Lok Sabha tally nearly halved to 33 from 62 seats it had won in 2019. The SP-Congress alliance on the other hand had won 43 of UP's 80 Lok Sabha seats. A senior SP leader admits that by fielding four Muslim candidates in nine constituencies, the party inadvertently played into the BJP's narrative of division.

The absence of the Congress from the electoral fray, after it failed to negotiate seat-sharing with the SP, further weakened the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). The lack of coordination was glaring, notes Brajesh Mishra, a Lucknow-based political scientist. While the BJP enjoys its moment of triumph, the onus is on the Opposition to regroup and rebuild ahead of the 2027 assembly election. ■

–Ashish Misra

Just two months ago, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee had offered to resign amid a tense standoff with junior doctors up in arms over the brutal rape and murder of a colleague at the R.G. Kar Medical College & Hospital in Kolkata.

Come November 23, and Mamata led the Trinamool Congress (TMC) to a clean sweep in the assembly bypolls, not only retaining and expanding its margins in five seats but also winning Madarihat—earlier with the BJP—for the first time. This win, despite initial waves of public anger, underscores the enduring loyalty of Bengal's rural electorate, largely attributed to Mamata's welfare schemes. The R.G. Kar protests, which once seemed a potent threat, now appear unlikely to sway the narrative leading up to the 2026 assembly election. The bypoll success also strengthens the TMC's position within the INDIA bloc.

For the BJP, the outcome is another blow to its morale in Bengal, further eroding the confidence of its cadre. Only a comprehensive reorganisation will help it salvage its position in Bengal's fiercely competitive political landscape. ■

–Arkamoy Datta Majumdar



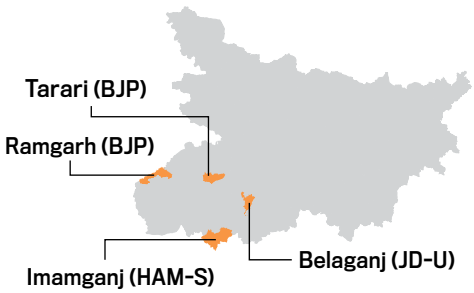
RAISING THE BAR Bihar CM Nitish Kumar

BIHAR

A CLEAN SWEEP

NDA triumphs, RJD stumbles in key battle before 2025 polls

Byelections in **4 seats** | Won by: **NDA**



Led by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) won all four seats in the Bihar assembly byelections, bolstering the coalition's position just months ahead of the critical 2025 state polls. What makes the clean sweep even more impressive is the fact that three of the seats—Tarari, Ramgarh and Belaganj—were previously held by the Opposition INDIA bloc. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) emerged victorious in the first two while Nitish's Janata Dal (United) clinched Belaganj. In Imamganj, Hindustani Awam Morcha (Secular)'s Deepa Kumari secured a win, keeping the seat within the NDA fold after her father-in-law and party's founder Jitan Ram Manjhi vacated the seat as he moved on to the Lok Sabha.